BOOKS ▼

The Human Cost



TABISH KHAIR'S SHARP NEW NOVEL EXPLORES REFUGEES AND DISPLACEMENT AS SYMPTOMS OF A LARGER MALAISE

The Denmark-based Indian novelist and poet Tabish Khair's latest book *Drown All the Refugees* derives its name from a line in Joseph Conrad's *Heart of Darkness*, where the unhinged Colonel Kurtz orders his men to kill without judgement, to "exterminate all the brutes". In Khair's novel, the narrator exclaims, "Drown all the refugees!" during a conversation at a literary festival, before explaining his nihilism to us, the readers. He says that for too long, brown people in the West had been pitied and tolerated but never accepted, and that "it is better to kill a human being than to pity him". Talking about this scene and the inception of the novel, Khair says, "It's very easy to focus on people who are genocidal in the literal sense. Most people are not like that. Most people at literary festivals are very good at offering a coin of sympathy, at making a symbolic gesture, and feeling that their job is done. I wanted to negotiate that situation."

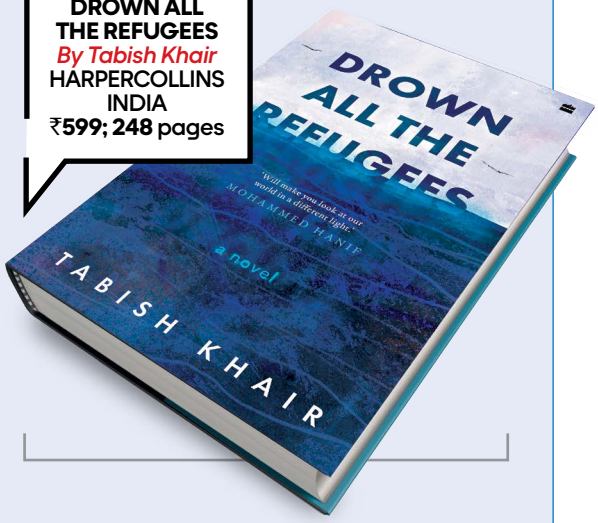
The novel's narrator is a gay man, an academic who's the sole surviving heir to a Pondicherry plantation estate. His outburst at the literary festival is informed by two very important people in his life—his deceased Palestinian boyfriend Abdul, and his childhood friend Pedro, who died in an attempt to illegally migrate to America.

"A refugee is an extreme manifestation of a much deeper problem," says Khair. "Our failure to engage humanely with refugees is a symptom of our failure to engage with differences within our society. If you look at Indian society, there are millions of folks who are internally displaced, who aren't even counted as refugees, technically. But their lives often have very similar problems as say, an Indian refugee in Europe."

Drown All the Refugees is another quick-witted, sure-footed outing for the versatile Khair. Anybody remotely interested in the whys and wherefores of migration would be well-advised to read it. ■

—Aditya Mani Jha

DROWN ALL THE REFUGEES
By Tabish Khair
HARPERCOLLINS INDIA
₹599; 248 pages



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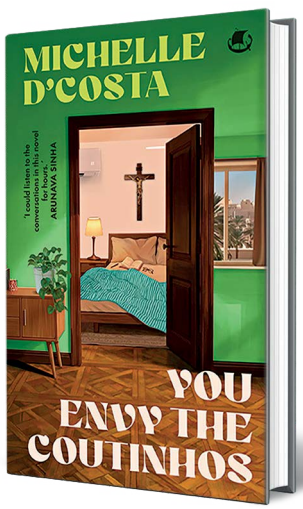
Recent book releases that shou

BACK TO THE FU

Zone, the much-awaited third part of Manjula Padmanabhan's Meiji trilogy, is out, more than a decade after the last entry. It charts Meiji's journey across the Zone, the future name of the continent we know as Africa. The previous books have been reissued with new cover illustrations by the author.

FAMILY MATTERS

Joachim Coutinho swaps his cesspit of a life in Mangalore for a job in Bahrain, but the gulf—pun intended—between the fantasy and the reality is stark. To make matters worse, his nephew Darrel aspires to the same life. Michelle D'Costa's debut novel is a spry account of the migrant experience.



YOU ENVY THE COUTINHOS
By Michelle D'Costa
WESTLAND/TRANQUEBAR
₹499; 200 pages